

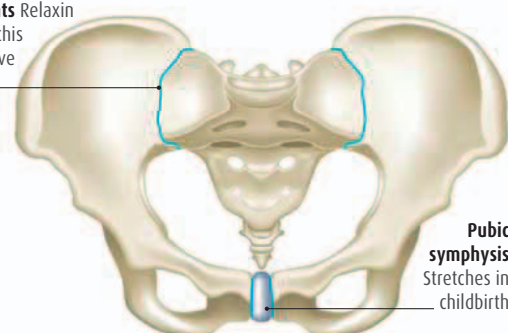
Q What are the best types of exercise during pregnancy?

Low- or no-impact exercise is ideal while you are pregnant, since it is easiest on your joints. Don't forget that any exercise that doesn't require you to try to maintain your balance over uneven or slippery ground is best.

The main goal of exercising through pregnancy is to strengthen your muscles, improve your circulation, ease any backache, and help you feel well. It's important to avoid any exercise or activities that require jumpy and jerky movements, take sharp changes of direction, or is so vigorous that it raises your

core temperature or puts excessive strain on your cardiovascular system or joints. In addition, impact sports and sports that involve a risk of falling—such as cycling, horse riding, downhill skiing, and contact sports—are not advisable. Some good choices are listed below.

Ligaments Relaxin loosens this connective tissue



Softer joints The hormone relaxin acts on the soft tissues connecting the bones of your pelvic cradle. This is great preparation for labor, but can cause aching pain beforehand. Go easy on your joints when exercising.

GREAT WAYS TO EXERCISE

Keep supple and elevate your heart rate without causing stress to your body with these options. Warm up gently, and stretch after.

» **Running, power walking, and walking:** if you are already running regularly, continuing is perfectly safe. Don't try to train for an event though. Run just below your usual fitness levels, and listen to your body if it tells you you've had enough. If you haven't previously been a runner, walking and power walking are great alternatives.

» **Cycling:** a low-impact form of exercise, cycling is good for your breathing and circulation. Because there's a risk of falling off your bike, especially after your belly begins to grow and your center of gravity and sense of balance begin to shift, it's safer to use a stationary bike during pregnancy. It's just as good for you. A recumbent bike, on which you sit back, not upright, puts less pressure on your perineum, and may feel more comfortable as your baby grows and bears downward.

» **Swimming:** as long as the pool is a normal temperature (not higher than 90° F/32° C), swimming is fantastic, since the buoyancy of the water supports your body. Best of all, as long as you feel comfortable, you can keep swimming right up until the moment you go into labor. A water aerobics class will be especially suited to your pregnant body.

» **Stretching and strengthening techniques:** exercise such as Pilates and yoga, when specially adapted for pregnancy, can be gentle on your muscles and ligaments, increase strength and flexibility, and improve your breathing to help you through labor. They are also good for easing back and hip pain (normal side effects of loosened ligaments) and preparing your body for birth. Always find a qualified teacher, since there are certain yoga postures and forms of Pilates that aren't suitable during pregnancy.

Softened ligaments

All the ligaments in your body become looser as a result of relaxin, which makes you more prone to injury and backaches

Uterus Relaxin is thought to relax the uterine wall muscles to inhibit contractions, allowing the uterus to expand. It may help to determine the timing of your labor

Pelvis The ligaments at the front of the pelvis in particular relax in preparation for childbirth. Your hips may feel more achy as a result and your pelvic cradle is less stable

Cervix and vagina Near the end of the pregnancy, relaxin widens and softens the cervix and vagina to ease delivery

Blood pressure

Relaxin influences your blood pressure by relaxing the blood vessels to increase blood flow, so helping more oxygen and nutrients reach the fetus

How your body changes

Relaxin is produced by the ovaries, placenta, and other tissues to help you deal with pregnancy and prepare for childbirth. Once released into the bloodstream, it affects your body in different ways at different times.

